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SUNDAY, NOVEMBER 9, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

High stakes for Johnson in push for head tax

Part of progressive revenue battle where mayor needs a win

By Alice Yin and Jake Sheridan
Chicago Tribune

An impassioned Mayor Brandon Johnson was in his element as he tailored his pitch to reinstate Chicago's corporate head tax during a recent West Englewood town hall.

"There's a reason why more of our people have left this city than any other group," Johnson told a mostly Black audience at the Nov. 1 town hall organized by his supporters. "We ought to demand the ultrarich do more, so that we can get more."

Standing in the mayor's way at that event was local Ald. David Moore, 17th, who said he sent out a robocall to his constituents ahead of the budget town hall to counter the pro-Johnson coalition's presence.

"We don't want those Black McDonald's operators to suffer. That's not what it's supposed to be about," Moore told the crowd. "I gotta deal with the little operator that's on 76th and Vincennes who may be impacted by this negatively, then he'll fire those kids or close down his place, and then it hurts our community."

The tension behind Johnson's pitch that day for a monthly \$21-per-employee tax on big companies is part of a larger progressive revenue battleground where the mayor desperately needs a win. Having already failed to deliver other key tenets of his ambitious tax-the-rich wish list, the head tax is a watershed moment for Johnson and his allies.

"Look, the baseball season just ended, so it's still fresh in mind: three strikes and you're out," Joe Ferguson, president of the Civic Federation watchdog group that opposes the head tax, said of Johnson's revenue woes. "It hasn't worked because the math hasn't been worked out, the justification hasn't been made beyond simply an ideologically driven critique."

Less than a year into Johnson's term, voters rejected the mayor's "Bring Chicago Home" tax referendum. His Springfield strategy of pressuring Gov. JB Pritzker and state lawmakers to tax the rich has similarly faltered so far. If John-

Turn to Tax, Page 7



'SMALL ACTS HAVE HUGE CONSEQUENCES'

Inside Chicago's growing resistance movement against Operation Midway Blitz

By Andrew Carter | Chicago Tribune

Baltazar Enriquez began wearing his whistle in June, when the threat of the Trump administration's immigration raids was more focused and the fear perhaps less widespread in Chicago. The whistle — green plastic, attached to an orange lanyard — was at first a small gesture of preparedness. It has since become a symbol of resistance.

In the beginning, the sight of it around Enriquez's neck prompted questions and confusion in Little Village, one of Chicago's proudest Latino neighborhoods. He remembers people asking him, perplexed: "What is a whistle gonna do?"

"And we said, 'Well, the whistle is in case immigration is around, and you start blowing. The whistle is for people who are undocumented to go away, to lock their doors, lock their gates and not open the door.'"

"And it grew like wildfire. Now everybody's using it."

IN CHICAGOLAND: DHS reports shots fired at immigration agents in Little Village as residents confront Bovino, Border Patrol. Page 3

For the past two months of President Donald Trump's so-called Operation Midway Blitz, federal agents have engaged in a norm-defying assault on the Chicago area. In Little Village, where Enriquez is president of the community council, restaurant doors have remained locked and business along 26th Street has slowed.

The resistance born there, though, has spread. A movement that began in Chicago's Latino enclaves has arrived

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Above: Baltazar Enriquez, president of the Little Village Community Council, blows a whistle as federal immigration officers depart on Oct. 23 after a raid at Discount Mall on West 26th Street in Chicago. BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Energy bill gives Illinois regulators new powers



An employee walks below the Unit 2 Diesel Generator inside the nuclear plant at the Braidwood Clean Energy Center in Braceville on Nov. 13, 2024. TESS CROWLEY/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Commerce Commission can order rates, how electricity is generated

By John Lippert and Jeremy Gerner
Chicago Tribune

As Illinois lawmakers finished their work for 2025, they began backing away from their four-year-old pledge that the state would produce electricity only from carbon-free sources by 2045.

They did so by conferring new powers on state regulators who had already signaled that closing coal- and gas-fired electricity plants as scheduled, starting in 2030, is likely impossible in the face of looming shortages and soaring monthly bills.

In a complex mosaic, they also empowered these same regulators to inject significant new horsepower into renewable and

Turn to Energy, Page 6

INSIDE



CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Bears 'right in the mix' for the playoffs

With Chicago as contenders, the Tribune's Brad Biggs looks at five reasons for optimism — and three for concern. Chicago Sports

Weekend session in Senate bogs down

A bipartisan solution remains elusive as the shutdown passes 39 days and is taking an increasing toll on the country. Nation & World

